

A course in language creation



Conlangs University

Verbs 2

Voice, evidentiality, & aktionsart



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Verbs 2

Hello everyone and welcome back to Conlangs University. This week we're circling back to verbs. Last time we talked about verbs, we covered tense and aspect, which tell you when something happened and mood, which tells you what the speaker thinks about the truth of the event. This week we're going to talk about a few more things that can happen with verbs.

Voice

Voice is a grammatical category that describes constructions marking the verb's relationship with its arguments. The default for transitive verbs is for the verb's agent to be the subject and the verb's patient to be the object. This is called the **active voice** and is usually unmarked. An example of the active voice is...pretty much any basic transitive sentence, such as "Slorany hugs Barbas," or "You read this lesson." Sometimes speakers have reasons to add and subtract arguments or to move them around. Here we'll talk about some different ways that languages tend to do that.

Passive and Antipassive

A typical transitive verb has an agent in a more prominent position and a patient in a less prominent position. Sometimes, a speaker might want to promote the patient to the more prominent position. A voice that promotes the patient to subject and demotes the agent is called a **passive**. In English, we form the passive periphrastically using the auxiliary verb *to be*. For example, the active voice sentence "Slorany hugs Barbas" gets passivized as "Barbas is hugged by Slorany." (Barbas is Slor's adorable dog, in case you don't know.) The patient, Barbas, gets promoted to subject, and the agent, Slorany gets bumped out of subject position. In English, the agent can be reintroduced after the verb in a prepositional phrase with *by*, but it's optional. One feature of the passive is that you can do away with the agent entirely, to make a sentence like "Barbas is hugged," where the agent is unknown or unspecified. In English, the passive voice is expressed analytically, using an auxiliary verb, but in many languages, for example Turkish (Turkic), the passive voice is marked morphologically on the verb.

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1. Pencere açıldı.  
   pencere aç  -ıl-dı  
   window open-PV-PST  
   "The window was opened."
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The passive voice can be useful for a couple of reasons. Sometimes the subject isn't known or the speaker doesn't want to specify it, like in sentence (1) where we don't know who opened the window. Other times, the speaker wants to maintain continuity by keeping some prominent noun as the subject across multiple clauses. In a sentence like "The boxer dodged the first punch but was hit by the second one," "the boxer" is

the agent of the first verb but the patient of the second, so to keep it in the subject position for both, you need some way of promoting a patient to subject. That's where the passive comes in.

Otherwise, passives can be used to shift focus away from the agent or indicate that the agent has fewer "agent-like" characteristics than a prototypical one might be. For example, in a sentence like "Alvaro got tested by the doctor," suggests that, even though he's the patient (no pun intended, I swear), Alvaro had some initiative in the process, which means he might be slightly more prominent in the event than your average patient. Sometimes voice can express that sort of thing. It's also worth noting that many languages have multiple passive voice constructions with various nuances. For example, some distinguish between events and enduring states, while others have a specific passive voice construction indicating that the patient was negatively affected by the action.

The same way you use a passive to demote the agent, sometimes you want to demote a patient. A voice that demotes the patient is called an **antipassive**. This can be useful to turn transitive verbs into intransitive verbs where the subject is the agent or indicate that the patient is unknown or unimportant. In some syntactically ergative languages where the patient of a transitive verb behaves like a subject, this can also be useful to promote the agent to subject. Antipassive voice constructions are more common in languages with ergative features, but this is not a hard-and-fast rule and languages may have both or neither. Here's an example from Dyirbal (Pama-Nyungan) which is notorious for showing a high degree of syntactic ergativity.

```
2. Baji jaɾa baniɲu baɣun ʒuɣumbilgu buɾalɲanu.  
   baji jaɾa   bani-ɲu   baɣun ʒuɣumbil-gu buɾal-ɲa -ɲu  
   M.ABS man.ABS come-NFUT F.DAT woman -DAT see -ANTP-NFUT  
   "The man came and saw the woman."
```

In English, you can drop the nominative argument if it's the same as the subject of a previous clause, but in Dyirbal you can drop the *absolutive* argument. (If you don't remember nominatives, absolutes, SAP, and all that, then flip back to the lesson on Morphosyntactic Alignment to jog your memory.) In this sentence, the subject of **bani come** is the same as the agent of **buɾal see**. In English, this poses no problem: they're both nominative, so drop the second one and you're good to go. But in Dyirbal, you can only drop co-referring *absolutes*, in order to drop the agent of a transitive verb like *see*, you have to promote it to subject of an intransitive verb using the antipassive voice. The agent *man* gets promoted to subject (and promptly dropped), and the patient *woman*, which would normally be the absolutive argument gets removed, and optionally reintroduced as an adjunct (here marked as dative). Antipassive can show up even in languages that don't show this same degree of syntactic ergativity, and many languages with ergative marking still make use of a passive construction, so don't feel like passive = nominative and antipassive = ergative when you're building your conlang.

Applicatives

Passive and antipassive both remove arguments from verbs, but what about adding an argument? Many languages have voices that take some oblique and promote it to the direct object. A voice that does this is called an **applicative**. Languages can use applicatives to promote any sort of argument, but it's most common for them to pick benefactors, instruments, or locations and promote them to direct object. Languages may have several different applicatives which are used to promote different kinds of things to

direct object. Here's an example from Tuscarora (Iroquoian) of how a directional applicative can add an argument to a verb. In sentence (4), "town" is not the patient of the verb meaning "to drive," so it can't appear by itself. It needs the directional applicative suffix *-t* on the verb to promote it to direct object.

3. Wakiʔθreʔ.
wak-iʔθre-ʔ
1SG-drive-IMPF
"I was driving along."
4. Utáʔnakeʔ yahękiʔθret
u-taʔn=akeʔ yah -waʔ-wak-iʔθre-t -ʔ
N-town=in.place TRNS-FAC-1SG-drive-APPL-P
"I drove into town."

If you apply an applicative and then a passive, then it can be possible to promote an oblique to subject. In some languages, the only way to express some roles is with an applicative. In some languages, like Swahili (Bantu), the only way to express a recipient is to introduce it with a benefactor applicative. There's a lot that applicatives can do, and if you choose to use them in your conlang, think through how they interact with the other parts of the sentence.

Symmetrical Voice

Passive and antipassive remove arguments and applicatives can add them. What about voices that keep things where they are? Some languages have voices that allow things to move around in the sentence, but don't add or subtract any arguments from the verb. Voices that don't affect a verb's transitivity are called **symmetrical voices**.

Rather than just having a transitive active and an intransitive passive, some languages distinguish between two transitive voices: an **agent voice**, where the agent is the subject, and a **patient voice**, where the patient is the subject. The speaker can choose whether to make the agent or patient more prominent depending on things like how important it is in the discourse or how it links up with other sentences, but either way, the verb stays transitive. Here's an example of active voice (5), patient voice (6), and passive voice (7) from Indonesian (Austronesian) so you can see how they differ. Passive and patient voices both make the patient prominent, but the passive has an optional agent in a prepositional phrase whereas the patient voice has to stay transitive.

5. Kami tidak akan membaca buku ini.
kami tidak akan mem-baca buku ini
1PL NEG FUT AV- read book this
"We will not read this book."

6. Buku ini tidak akan kami baca.
buku ini tidak akan kami baca
book this NEG FUT 1PL read
"This book, we won't read." or "This book won't be read by us."

7. Buku ini tidak akan dibaca (oleh Ana).
buku ini tidak akan di-baca (oleh Ana)
book this NEG FUT PV-read (by Ana)
"This book won't be read (by Ana)."

Symmetrical voices allow you to move a verb's arguments around, but don't change transitivity, whereas the passive allows an argument to be omitted with an indefinite meaning or introduced back somewhere else in the sentence.

Evidentiality

Evidentiality is a linguistic category that marks how a speaker knows the piece of information that a sentence conveys. English tends to convey this sort of information with adverbs like *apparently* or *supposedly*, but in many languages it's grammaticalized. A common contrast is between information that the speaker has direct knowledge of and information that the speaker has inferred. In Turkish, there are two separate past-tense markers: **-di** for direct information and **-miş** for indirect information.

8. Ayşe buraya geldi.
Ayşe bura-ya gel -di
Ayşe here-ALL come-PST.DIR
"Ayşe came here."

9. Ayşe buraya gelmiş.
Ayşe bura-ya gel -miş
Ayşe here-ALL come-PST.IND
"Ayşe must have come here."

In sentence (8), maybe the speaker was here at the same time as Ayşe, so they know for a fact that she was here, but in sentence (9), maybe the speaker left out a letter for each of their friends and noticed that Ayşe's has been taken, so they can infer that she must have been here (otherwise who took her letter?).

A lot of conlangers see evidentiality as being a kind of "exotic" feature, since it seems unfamiliar to speakers of Indo-European languages, but you can actually see it in English if you know where to look. Go back to the English translations of (8) and (9). What exactly is the meaning that "must" contributes in (9)? It gives a sense that the speaker didn't witness it directly, but based on the evidence, it has to have happened. "Must" is doing double-duty as a modal and as an evidential marker.

Many languages go even deeper than just a two-way distinction between direct and indirect knowledge. Some languages mark the source of information more specifically. Some common types of markings include **firsthand** for information about something the speaker personally witnessed, **hearsay** for information the speaker learned from someone else, **inferred** for something the speaker inferred based on circumstantial evidence, or **assumed** for something the speaker assumes based on common knowledge. Some languages go a step further and distinguish an event witnessed visually from an event witnessed by another sense, or hearsay from a reputable source from hearsay from an irreputable source. If you choose to include evidentials, think about what distinctions in information might be important to your speakers (or to people in general), but don't go overboard. Also think about how evidentiality can interact with other parts of your language, like how in English (and many other languages), modal verbs can contribute evidential meaning.

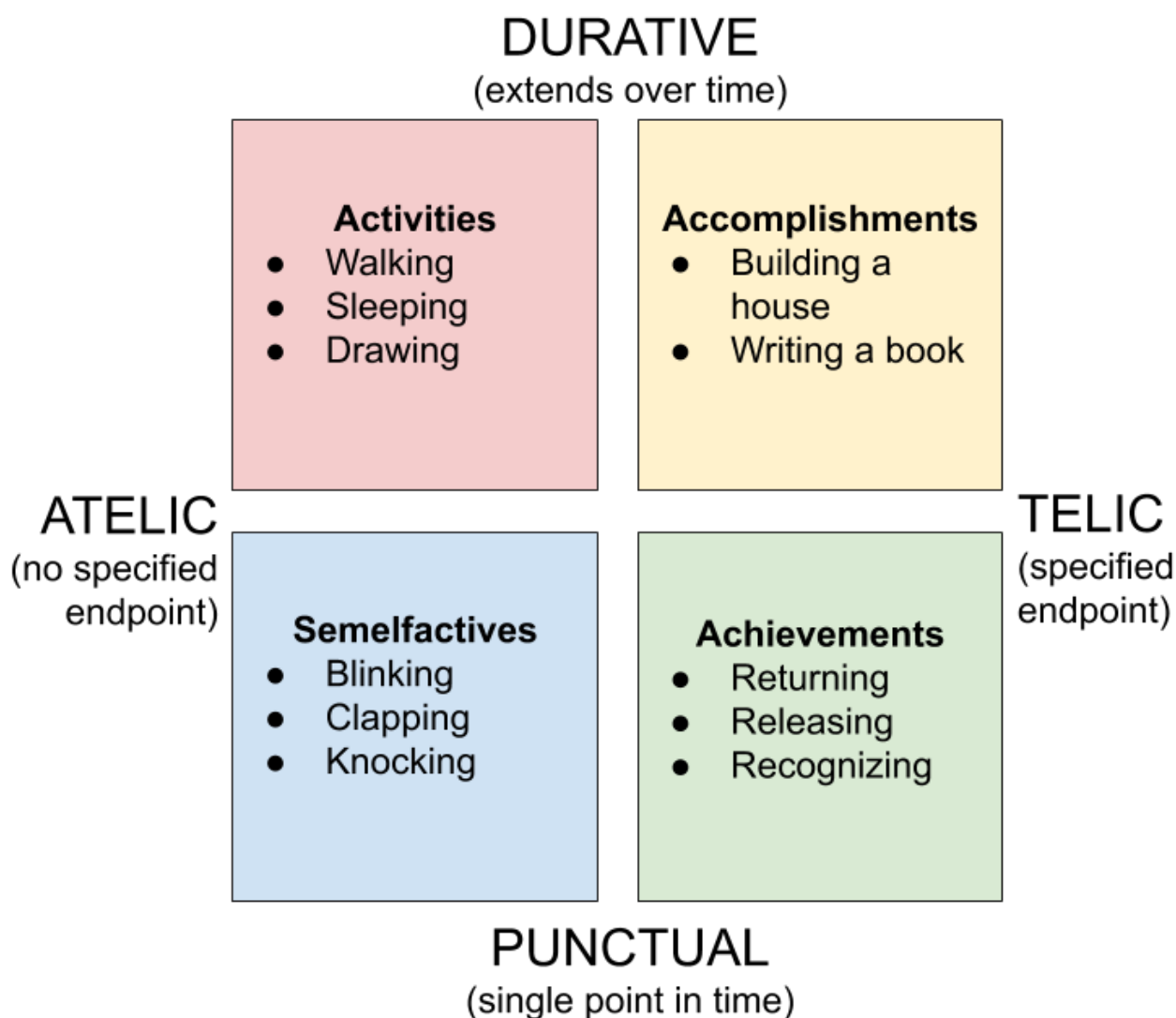
Lexical Aspect a.k.a. Aktionsart

Last time we talked about verbs, we discussed grammatical aspect, which describes how the event time relates to the topic time. Now it's time for something related but distinct. **Lexical aspect**, also known by its German name **Aktionsart**, describes how the event or state described by a verb is structured in time. Lexical aspect isn't something that's marked on the verb, but rather a property baked into a particular verb or verb phrase that tends to interact with other things going on in the sentence. Predicates can be loosely grouped into **states**, which do not involve any change, and **events** which do involve some sort of change. The predicates "know how to speak French" or "be red" are states because they refer to unchanging qualities, whereas the predicates "learn how to speak French" or "turn red" are events because they refer to occasions where things change. You can see differences between these two categories in English grammar. Verbs describing states can't usually take the present progressive, unlike verbs describing events. Sentences with states like "I am knowing how to speak French" or "It is being red" sound incorrect, but sentences with events like "I am learning how to speak French" or "It is turning red" are totally normal. When you're creating a conlang, think about ways that these can interact with the meaning of the verb system. It's common, for example, for states to combine differently with aspect marking than events.

Events can be divided further along two axes: telic/atelic and punctual/durative. A **punctual** predicate describes an event that happens at a single point in time whereas a **durative** one is one that happens over a longer time, *i.e.* it has a duration. Clapping is punctual because it happens at a single moment, but writing is durative because it can happen over a long period of time. A **telic** predicate is one which reaches a specified endpoint, and an **atelic** one is one which doesn't. Crossing the street is telic because there's a natural endpoint where you've crossed the street and the event is over, but walking around is atelic because there's no natural endpoint. You could conceivably walk around for as long as you want. Telicity isn't inherent to verbs either. Sometimes adding or changing a direct object can affect telicity. Writing is atelic. It could go on as long as you want. But writing *a book* is telic because there's a natural endpoint: finishing the book. When I say that "writing a book" is telic, I don't mean the action itself, but rather the predicate used to describe the action. If someone is sitting down writing a book, then it's equally true to describe what they're doing using the telic "writing a book" as it is using the atelic "writing." Telicity is a property of an events description, not the event itself. (Thanks to Priscianic for clarification and examples!)

Based on the axes of punctuality and telicity, event predicates can be grouped into four classes. Predicates that are durative and atelic, like writing or walking around are called **activities**. Ones that are durative

and telic are called **accomplishments**. Examples include things like writing a book or crossing the street, that take time, but culminate in a natural endpoint. Predicates that are telic and punctual, happening at a single point in time, are called **achievements**. Achievements describe events whose culmination happens immediately, such as recognizing or releasing. There's a clear before and after the achievement, but no duration. Last, predicates that are atelic and punctual are called **semelfactives**. This is a kind of funny category that mostly includes predicates that describe individual events in a series of repeated events. Things like knocking, tapping or blinking.



Although these categories aren't marked directly, they can often affect other things in the sentence, especially relating to how a language expresses time. You've already seen how state predicates in English don't like (aren't liking?) to appear in the progressive. Another cool example from English is in expressions of duration: duration of a telic predicate is introduced with the preposition "in," but duration of an atelic predicate is introduced with the preposition "for." Compare an accomplishment like "he crossed the street **in** two minutes" with an activity like "he walked around **for** two minutes." In Navajo (Na-Dené), there's an aspect specifically for semelfactive predicates. In Cantonese (Sino-Tibetan), there's a perfective marker that's only used with accomplishment predicates. Examples where constructions depend on lexical aspect abound. When you create verbs, think about how they fit into classes like these, and how that might affect how they fit into sentences in your language.

Non-finite Forms

Most commonly, verbs are used as the main predicate of a sentence or clause. A verb form that can show up as a clause's main predicate is considered **finite**. On the other hand, a verb form that can't be used as a clause's main predicate is considered **non-finite**. Here, we'll talk about types of non-finite verbs that behave like nouns, ones that behave like adjectives, and ones that behave like adverbs.

Infinitives and Nominalizations

Sometimes you want to talk to an event or state, but rather than asserting that something takes part in that event or is in that state, you want to talk about the event or state as a thing. In that case, you want some way of turning a verb into a noun. This is called a **nominalization**. Nominalizations can be small, consisting of just the plain verb, such as "speaking" or they can be large, consisting of entire nominalized verb phrases, such as "speaking a language which nobody else here can understand." They generally behave the same way nouns do. They can be assigned case, take articles, be possessed, occur as subjects or objects of verbs, and so on. Here's an example of a clausal nominalization being assigned locative case from Galo (Sino-Tibetan).

10. Taníi gə`hóbbə̀m padāk lò ɲó ʔinɲíi tó.
taníi=gə` hóbbə̀ =ə̀m pá -dāk=lò ɲó ʔin-ɲíi -tó
tani =GEN mithun=ACC cut-COS=LOC 1SG go -abandon-PFV
"I left during Tani's killing of the mithun."

In case you're wondering (I know I was), a mithun is a kind of cattle. Here, the whole nominalization is assigned case as a single noun phrase, and the subject of the verb looks like a possessor, marked with the genitive case. This happens in English too, where "Tani" is the possessor of "killing of the mithun." It turns out that this structure, where the subject of a nominalized verb shows up as the possessor of the nominalization, is very common cross-linguistically. Nominalizations can be expressed in different ways. Some languages have a dedicated **verbal noun** form used in nominalizations. Others have nominalizing particles or allow zero-conversion: nominalization with zero overt marking.

Another somewhat noun-y verb form is the **infinitive**, a verb form that heads clauses without overt subjects and usually without tense, aspect, or mood marking. Infinitives are familiar as the English *to*-form of a verb. Similarly to nouns, infinitives can occur as complements of verbs, such as in sentences like "I want *to learn* more," or as subjects of verbs, like in the proverb "*to err* is human." Infinitives are not fully interchangeable with nouns in the way that nominalizations are, however, as they can't be assigned case, take articles, or be possessed.

Participles

Many languages have verb forms that are used to modify nouns, essentially turning verb phrases into adjectives with meanings similar to relative clauses. These forms are called **participles**. Two different

types of participles are probably familiar to you from English. We have a present participle, marked with the suffix *-ing*, which creates a modifier saying that a noun is currently performing an action. "A running man" is "a man who is running." We also have a past participle saying that a noun has undergone an action, slightly more irregular than the present participle, but usually marked with *-ed*. "A constructed language" is "a language which has been constructed."

Languages with participles often make distinctions about not only the tense or aspect of the verb, but also the role that the noun being modified has in relation to the verb. Languages often contrast between **active** participles, where the noun being modified is the agent of the verb and **passive** participles, where the noun being modified is the patient of the verb. (If you look at the English examples, the past participle is usually a passive participle. When you say "constructed language," it's the language being constructed, not doing the constructing.) In English, participle phrases are mostly limited to a verb and maybe an adverb or, with a present a participle, a verb-object combo, like "man-eating tiger." But in many other languages, any verb phrase can be made into a participle. In some languages, like Turkish, the normal way to construct a relative clause is to turn it into a participle phrase. (This has the interesting side-effect that the only things that can be heads of relative clauses are things that can be referred to with a participle. If you can't make a participle that refers to a possessor, for example, then there's no way you can relativize it.)

```
11. Bana şimdi konuşan adam nerede?
    bana   şimdi konuş-an   adam nere -de
    1SG.DAT now   speak-PTCP man   where-LOC
    "Where is the man who is speaking to me now?"
```

In some languages, participles don't refer to specific roles, but instead depend on context. You can see an example of this in the conlang *Kíлта*, by William Annis, whose participles can refer to whatever role is most contextually relevant. A human is more likely to find something and a book is more likely to be found, so with the same participle, you can get either an active or a passive meaning. The contextually relevant role doesn't have to be an argument of the verb either. It can just as easily be an adjunct like the location in (13).

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12. Ėchúkërin chëvan
    ėchúk   -ërin   chëvan
    encounter-PFV.PTCP woman
    "A woman who found [something]"
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13. Ėchúkërin para
    ėchúk   -ërin   para
    encounter-PFV.PTCP book
    "A book which [someone] found"
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14. Ha konërin onnit
    ha   kon   -ërin   onnit
    1SG sleep-PFV.PTCP room
    "A room in which I slept"
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A non-finite verb which modifies a clause as an adverb can be called a **converb**. English participles can act as adverbs, for example "running" acts to modify the manner in "He came running up to me." Some languages have converb forms that perform similar functions to English adverbial subordinators like while, before, after, or because. Here are some examples from Nivkh (Isolate) and Udmurt (Uralic).

15. If ɬarkr təvəɖ.

if ɬark-r təvə -d

3SG jump-CONV enter.house-IND

"He jumped into the house" (lit. "He entered the house while jumping.")

16. Džok šōry pukśysa no Boris ōz śišky.

Džok šōry pukśy-sa no Boris ō -z śišky

table at sit -CONV also Boris NEG-PST.3SG eat

"Even after sitting down at the table, Boris did not eat."

Converbs are especially common in verb-final languages, where they may come to entirely replace adverbial subordination constructions. Some languages have a large number of converbs with very specific uses, and others have a smaller number with more vague meanings. Even in languages that don't have large systems of converbs, there are still often constructions allowing verbs to act like adverbial modifiers, like English adverbial gerunds in sentences like "Rushing out of the house, I nearly forgot my keys," where "rushing" heads an adverbial phrase in the same manner as a converb.

Between Verbs I and Verbs II, you've gotten a typological overview of some of the things verbs can do. Cool. So what?

When you're creating a conlang, it's important to understand all of the different things that a language can do, and to consider if and how your language does those things. When I started conlanging, my projects were very similar to English, simply because I didn't know what my options were, so it never occurred to me that I could make something different. Of course the possibilities are infinite, and these two lessons barely scratch the surface. But with this basic overview, you're equipped to start thinking about what your verbs do and learn more about all the other things that natlangs can do. Here are some questions to consider when creating a verbal system.

- How many verbs are there? Do there tend to be many distinct verbs, or a smaller number of verbs used with a variety of objects? Does your language prefer constructions like "converse" or "have a conversation"?
- What gets lexicalized as a verb? Events are almost always verbs, but how about states? Are there verbs with adjectival meaning like "to be red"?
- Do your verbs agree with their arguments? If so, with what features of which arguments?
- Are your verbs marked for tense, aspect or mood? What do the different markings mean and how do their meanings combine with each other? Are there any combinations that aren't allowed?
- How do a verb's arguments relate to the roles of the event described by it? Are there constructions to change the structure of the arguments? To add or remove arguments?
- Does your language mark evidentiality (on the verbs or elsewhere)? What types of information source does it distinguish between?
- What sorts of verb forms does your language have other than the ones used in main clauses? Adverbial, nominal, or adjectival forms? How do they work?